people simply had to learn how to govern their nation properly, ‘and if you want them to do that it’s no use fiddling with them, and their affairs, still less intervening and pretending you don’t’.[11] The idea of simply letting the Persians get on with things while Britain took a back-seat had, of course, long been advocated by the Indian government. Indeed, such language by Loraine is reminiscent of views put forward during the Eastern Committee debates on Persia in late 1918. Had Loraine tried to follow such a policy of detachment in 1919, however, no doubt he would have found himself at odds with Curzon. Yet by 1922, the foreign secretary was so disgruntled with the entire Persian situation that Loraine’s haughty aloofness was well received in the Foreign Office. In the wake of the debacle which was the Anglo-Persian Agreement and a number of years of failed interference in Persia’s internal affairs, it also seemed worth trying a change in tactic. After all, there appeared few other options for Britain by this time.

A further reason that Loraine tended to have London’s approval was that, as noted, despite the prophecies of Curzon, Cox and Mallet in 1918, the retreat of Britain’s influence in Persia did not portend the fall of that country to Bolshevism. Indeed, if one believed all the anti-Bolshevik rhetoric with which Curzon had surrounded his creation of the Anglo-Persian Agreement, one would be fairly surprised by the lack of progress the Bolshevik regime had made in Persia by 1922. As previously noted, the Soviet-Persian Agreement concluded in 1921 did not hail a particularly close friendship between the two signatories. Indeed, it in no way prevented the Persian government from actions which were in fact a complete violation of the terms of this treaty, including, for example, the seizure of Russian property within that country.[12] In January 1922 Loraine telegrammed home that the Bolsheviks had apparently become thoroughly sick of the Persians and their methods (perhaps also referring to the obfuscating of the latter when it came to having the agreement ratified by the Medjliss).[13] It also seemed that the Bolsheviks were regretting having given up all of Russia’s previous privileges within Persia, realising all too late the bargaining value of these concessions when it came to dealing with the Persian government (a lesson from the Great Game they should have taken note of).[14] The new Bolshevik representative in Tehran, Theodore Rothstein, remarked to an American journalist that the Persians: